

on mentioning his name.

Sanjay met Dr Deshpande through a mutual acquaintance and came to know that after the successful IPO of Sycamore Networks, the latter wanted to build something in India. "Speaking to him was like talking to a legend, since at that point in time, he was the richest Indian in the world! I expressed my desire to start a new venture and become an entrepreneur like him. Despite my lack of telecom equipment experience, he assured me we could figure it out," he says, the smile never wearing off from his face.

For someone who had spent 13 years in electronic design automation, Sanjay saw potential in the telecommunications sector and decided to venture into it. "Despite not knowing the field, I was confident I could figure it out," he says. The confidence, along with support from Dr Gururaj 'Desh' Deshpande, propelled him to set up Tejas Networks in 2000 along with his two co-founders Arnob Roy and Dr Kumar Sivarajan.

The startup faced numerous challenges. Product development in India was unprecedented, funding by VCs in product startups was difficult, and customers such as BSNL were sceptical, since they felt safer buying from established foreign equipment suppliers. Despite these challenges, Tejas Networks successfully raised US\$100 million of VC funding, built world-class optical networking products and saw exponential financial growth from inception till 2007 and was readying for IPO. The company faced their first headwinds when the financial markets froze after the 2007-2008 financial crisis and its IPO plans were shelved. To make matters worse, competition from the state-backed Chinese companies, who undercut prices, was brutal. This was followed by a series of unexpected external challenges that pushed the company to the wall. Its largest international customer Nortel filed for bankruptcy in 2009, the 2G scam in India in 2010 froze the buying of all telecom equipment, and a natural calamity—cyclone 'Thane' in 2012—submerged their manufacturing facility located in Pondicherry under six metres of water.

Sanjay pauses to take a breath while recalling every hurdle and then with a solemn smile says, "From a peak of ₹6 billion in 2006, our revenues plummeted to ₹2 billion by 2012-2013. Yet, we kept our heads down, preserved cash, and continued to invest in R&D, even when it seemed insane."

One would think that the cyclone was the final blow, but would be wrong. Sanjay goes on, "We moved to a new office on the way to Electronic City in Bengaluru, occupying three floors in a multi-storied building. Three months later, another office in the



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